

STEPPING IN CM-designate Atishi addresses the media with senior AAP leaders

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earlier than his detractors would have anticipated. Analysts call his resignation a "political weapon" that seeks to wrest back the moral high ground. But for that to fructify fully, AAP desperately needs to get out of the shadow of the excise policy case before the election. Kejriwal has even demanded early polls—along with the Maharashtra election in November—but the Election Commission is unlikely to concede the demand. Delhi is due for polls in five months, in February 2025.

"It's a very sad moment that Delhi's beloved CM has had to resign today due to the BJP's conspiracy," Atishi said after emerging out of the AAP legislative party meeting. But it does mean that Delhi gets its third woman chief minister, a decade after Kejriwal rode to power ousting the Congress's Sheila Dikshit. Despite Atishi's self-deprecation, some of the spotlight will shift to her own passage, now that she's cast in a leadership position for the first time. A change of face at the helm also deflects the attacks on Kejriwal, freeing him from the responsibilities of office to take a hands-on role in the election campaign, first for the Haryana assembly and then in Delhi.

Atishi's political graph had seen a spectacular rise in the absence of Sisodia and other senior leaders. The first-time MLA was handling 13 depts

Those in the know say this was not a "gamble", as some political pundits have it. This was the only way to take the wind out of the BJP's sails ahead of the election. Kejriwal's bail conditions, among other things, forbid him from going to the CM's office, and even signing on important files. When Kejriwal made bail on September 13, the BJP was caustic in its reaction, saying that encumbered by restrictions, he would remain a CM "just for show". Two days later, he had found a way around it to benefit the party in more ways than one.

The AAP supremo has talked of an "*agnipariksha*" (trial by fire) where he would go to the "people's court" to prove his innocence, adding that he would only return to the CM's chair if he passed it. The plan is simple then. The resignation turns the allegations of corruption into AAP's election issue as much as the BJP's. If AAP returns to power, it's the people's verdict, and in their court Kejriwal and Co. are innocent. The ongoing court cases will then cease to be a political threat.

"Arvindji will focus on organisation, travel to other parts of the country, like Haryana, to strengthen the party. Atishiji will ensure that there is no let-up on the governance side in the delivery of government services," says a senior AAP functionary. Delivery of public services, be it through the mohalla clinics, hospitals and the heavy subsidies in electricity and water bills are a key part of AAP's appeal, especially to its core voters among the urban poor, so it cannot afford any blips in that plan.

It's no sure-shot formula for success, though. But then, nothing in politics is. For AAP, from its origins in the India Against Corruption movement, its claims of clean governance, transparency and a direct connect with the electorate have been a matter of pride. Kejriwal's legal woes over the 'liquor scam' threaten to undercut this message. His second-in-command, Manish Sisodia, parrots the same "people's court" and "verdict on honesty" talk, but even he is severely constrained. In another time, without the shadow of corruption hanging over them, Sisodia—also out on bail in the same case—would have been the natural choice to succeed Kejriwal.